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STARS SHINE BRIGHT

World champion and tournament favourite Spain **continues to impress** in the Womens EURO.

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The Women's EURO 2025 in the Playground of Europe — Switzerland — entered its make-or-break stage as the eight teams marched their way into the knockout stage.

It was a dominant showing from all four group winners — Norway, Spain, Sweden and France — in the first phase of the competition after each recorded three wins in three. World champion and tournament favourite Spain was the most impressive of the lot, bagging 14 goals and conceding just three in that period. Spain's bid for a

first-ever European Championship title is spearheaded by two-time Ballon d'Or Féminin winner Alexia Putellas (**above, No. 11**), who has three goals and four assists in three starts in the tournament.

In the quarters, La Roja will face host Switzerland, which will play its first-ever knockout game in the EURO, after dramatically securing second place in its group behind Norway.

In its final group stage game against Finland, Swiss midfielder Riola Xhemaili found the net in the 92nd minute to level the game at 1-1 and edge its opponent on goal difference.

Elsewhere, England had a rough start to its title defence, losing 1-2 to

France, and became the first reigning champion to lose its opening fixture in Women's EURO history. However, the Lionesses bounced back in style, thrashing heavyweight Netherlands 4-0 and neighbour and debutant Wales 6-1 to secure a knockout spot behind France.

Rising tide

While the European Championship was underway, across the globe in the South Asian region, some nations were scripting their own history during the AFC Women's Asian Cup 2026 qualifiers.

India managed to go unbeaten during the whole qualifying campaign and punched its ticket to